



long, needlelike bill for reaching deep into flowers

slender, tilttable wings

Booted racket-tail hummingbird

Ocreatus underwoodii

Tiny clumps of loose white feathers on the thighs make the booted racket-tail a member of a group of hummingbirds called pufflegs. It is a common species in humid forests. Hummingbirds hover by flapping their wings in a figure-eight pattern. These remarkable birds can fly sideways and even backward.

Hummingbirds feed on nectar from scented, sugar-rich flowers, often red blossoms, hovering while licking up fluid with their long, slender tongue. They snap up small insects, too, and females capture thousands to provide growing chicks with vital protein.

Polygamous parents

Male booted racket-tails demonstrate their fitness to females in rapid, swooping display flights. The showiest males mate with several females, and each female may mate with a number of males, but she alone makes the nest and rears her brood of two chicks. The nest of fibers and moss is a tiny cup, placed on a bare, horizontal twig. It has a strong, elastic binding of cobwebs that expands as the chicks grow.

shiny green plumage

△ MID-AIR HOSTILITY

Males defend feeding territories around fresh blossoms, chasing off other males and even bumblebees, with aerial displays and rapid darting flights.

↔ 7–9 in (17–23 cm)

⚖ 1/8 oz (3 g)

⊗ Common

🍷 Nectar, insects, spiders

🏠 🌳 🌿



NW. to W.
South
America

long tail adornment of male

Booted racket-tails **beat their wings 60 times per second** when hovering